PHISHING EMAIL THREAT ANALYSIS & SECURITY AWARENESS REPORT

A Detailed Analysis of Phishing Emails, Risk Identification, and User Awareness Strategies

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1. Introduction

Phishing is one of the most common and dangerous forms of cyberattacks, where attackers attempt to trick users into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, financial details, or personal data by impersonating trusted entities.

With the increasing use of email communication, phishing attacks have become more sophisticated, using social engineering techniques such as urgency, fear, and trust exploitation.

This report focuses on identifying and analyzing phishing emails to understand their characteristics, risks, and preventive measures.

2. Objective

The objective of this project is to:

- Identify phishing emails using real-world examples
- Analyze phishing indicators such as spoofed senders, malicious links, and social engineering techniques
- Classify emails based on risk (Safe / Suspicious / Phishing)
- Explain the impact of phishing attacks in simple business language
- Provide awareness and prevention guidelines for users

3. Scope & Ethics

This project was conducted under strict ethical guidelines.

Scope of analysis includes:
- Publicly available phishing email examples
- non-intrusive analysis
- Educational and awareness-focused study

The following activities were NOT performed:
- Sending phishing emails
- Exploiting users or systems
- Accessing unauthorized data

This project is intended purely for cybersecurity learning and awareness purposes.

4. Methodology

The following approach was used for phishing email analysis:

1. Collection of phishing email samples from publicly available sources
2. Examination of each email based on:
   - Sender details
   - Subject line
   - Content and tone
   - Links and attachments
3. Identification of phishing indicators such as:
   - Spoofed email addresses
   - Urgent or threatening language
   - Suspicious links
4. Classification of emails as phishing based on observed indicators
5. Documentation of risks and preventive measures

5. Common Phishing Indicators

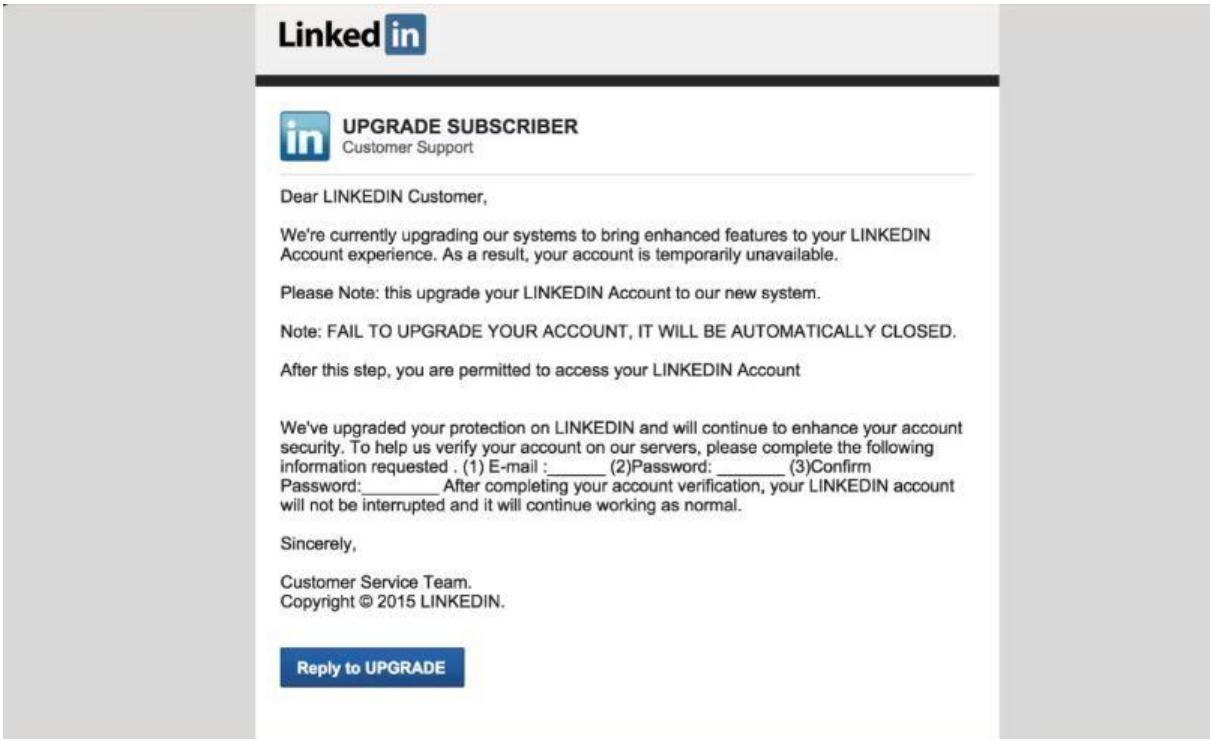
The following indicators were used to identify phishing emails:

- Fake or spoofed sender email addresses
- Urgent or threatening language
- Suspicious or shortened links
- Requests for sensitive information (passwords, OTP, bank details)
- Poor grammar or unusual formatting
- Unexpected attachments or offers

These indicators help in detecting phishing attempts effective.

6. Findings:

Email 1 — LinkedIn Phishing Email



Linked in

UPGRADE SUBSCRIBER
Customer Support

Dear LINKEDIN Customer,

We're currently upgrading our systems to bring enhanced features to your LINKEDIN Account experience. As a result, your account is temporarily unavailable.

Please Note: this upgrade your LINKEDIN Account to our new system.

Note: FAIL TO UPGRADE YOUR ACCOUNT, IT WILL BE AUTOMATICALLY CLOSED.

After this step, you are permitted to access your LINKEDIN Account

We've upgraded your protection on LINKEDIN and will continue to enhance your account security. To help us verify your account on our servers, please complete the following information requested . (1) E-mail :_____ (2)Password: _____ (3)Confirm Password:_____ After completing your account verification, your LINKEDIN account will not be interrupted and it will continue working as normal.

Sincerely,

Customer Service Team.
Copyright © 2015 LINKEDIN.

Reply to UPGRADE

Figure 1: Suspicious LinkedIn Email

Subject: Upgrade Subscriber / Account Upgrade Required
Sender: (Not clearly visible / appears to be LinkedIn support)
Email Type: Phishing

Sender email not clearly visible, which itself is suspicious.

DESCRIPTION:

The email claims to be from LinkedIn and informs the user that their account needs to be upgraded. It warns that failure to upgrade will result in account closure. The email also asks the user to provide sensitive information such as email and password.

ANALYSIS

This email is a classic example of a phishing attack that uses fear and urgency to trick users into revealing their login credentials. By pretending to be LinkedIn support, the attacker attempts to gain unauthorized access to user accounts. The request for password confirmation is a strong indicator of malicious intent.

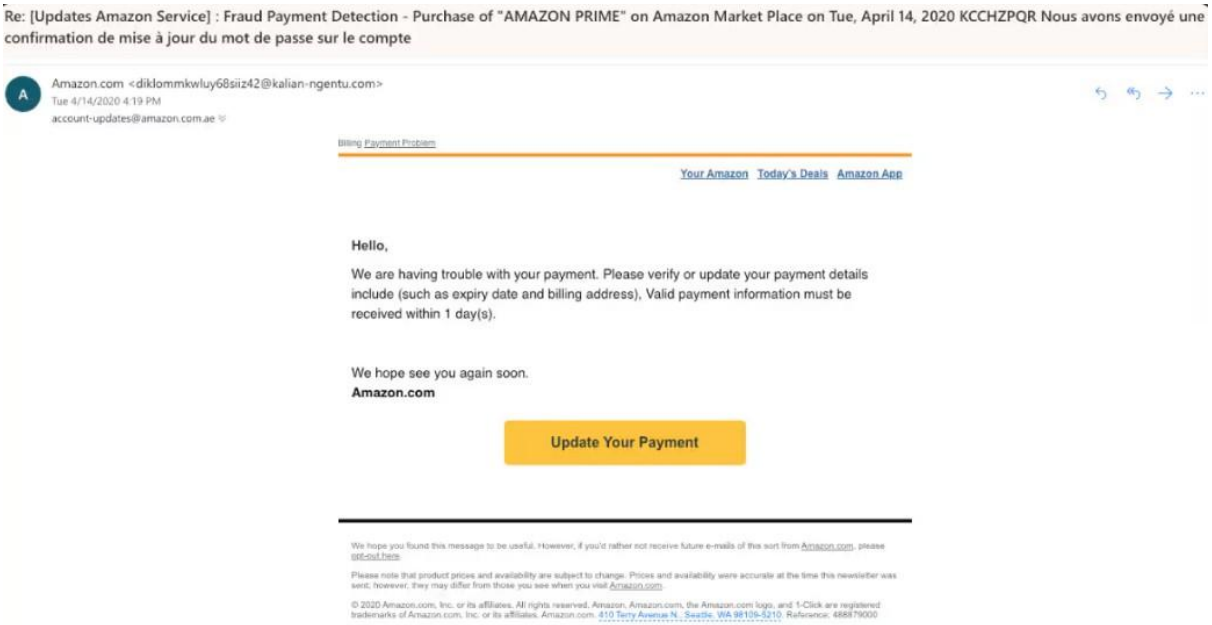
RISK/IMPACT

If a user falls for this email, the attacker can gain access to their LinkedIn account. This may lead to identity theft, misuse of personal data, and further phishing attacks targeting the user's connections.

PREVENTION:

- Do not click on suspicious links or buttons in emails.
- Always verify the sender's email address.
- Never share passwords or sensitive information via email.
- Access LinkedIn directly through the official website instead of email links.
- Enable two-factor authentication (2FA) for added security.

Email 2 — Amazon Payment Fraud Phishing Email


Re: [Updates Amazon Service] : Fraud Payment Detection - Purchase of "AMAZON PRIME" on Amazon Market Place on Tue, April 14, 2020 KCCHZPQR Nous avons envoyé une confirmation de mise à jour du mot de passe sur le compte

Amazon.com <dikIommkwluy68siiz42@kalian-ngentu.com>
Tue 4/14/2020 4:19 PM
account-updates@amazon.com.ae

Billing Payment Problem

Your Amazon Today's Deals Amazon App

Hello,

We are having trouble with your payment. Please verify or update your payment details include (such as expiry date and billing address), Valid payment information must be received within 1 day(s).

We hope see you again soon.
Amazon.com

Update Your Payment

We hope you found this message to be useful. However, if you'd rather not receive future e-mails of this sort from Amazon.com, please opt-out here.

Please note that product prices and availability are subject to change. Prices and availability were accurate at the time this newsletter was sent, however, they may differ from those you see when you visit Amazon.com.

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Figure 2: Suspicious Amazon Payment Email

Subject: Fraud Payment Detection – Purchase of Amazon Prime

Sender: account-updates@amazon.com (appears legitimate but needs verification)

Email Type: Phishing

DESCRIPTION

This email appears to be from Amazon and informs the user about a payment issue related to an Amazon Prime purchase. It asks the user to verify or update their payment details within a short time frame. The email includes a button labeled “Update Your Payment,” which may redirect users to a malicious website.

ANALYSIS

This email is a typical phishing attempt that impersonates Amazon to trick users into providing their financial information. By creating urgency and referencing a supposed fraudulent transaction, the attacker attempts to panic the user into clicking the provided link. Such links often lead to fake login pages designed to capture sensitive data like credit card details or account credentials.

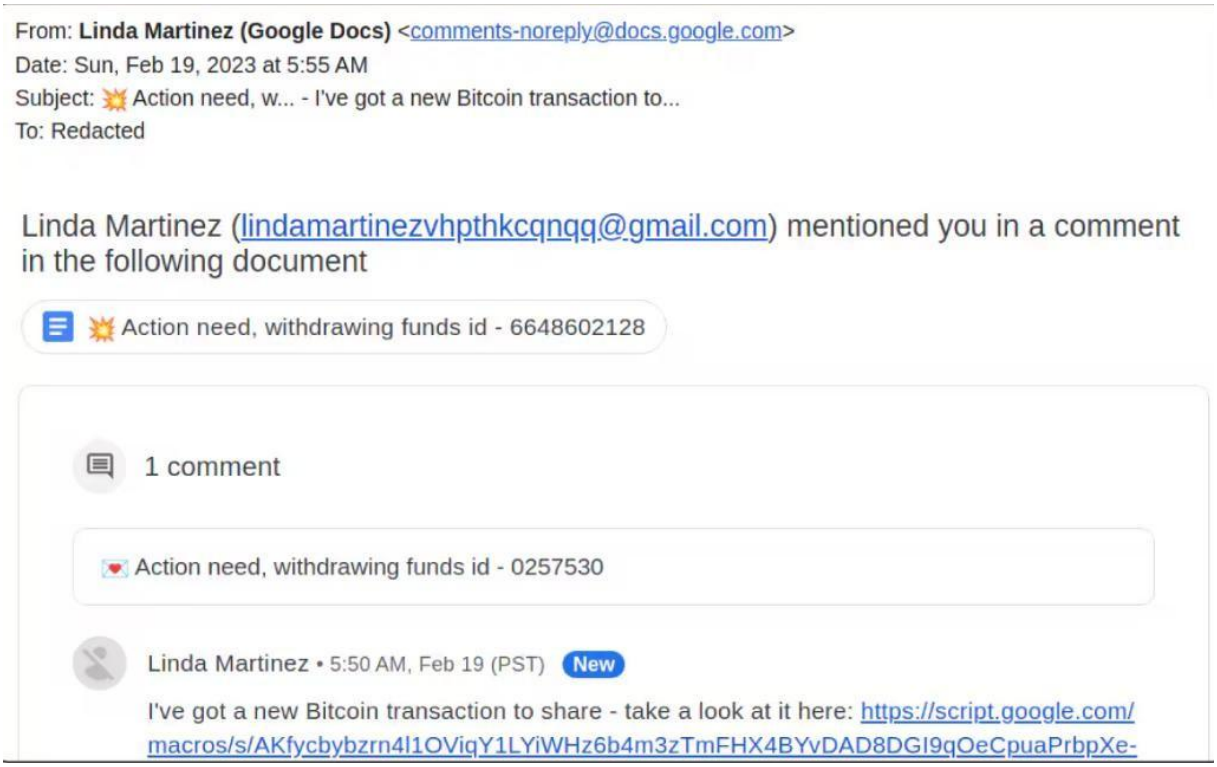
RISK / IMPACT

If a user clicks the link and enters their payment details, the attacker may gain access to sensitive financial information. This can lead to unauthorized transactions, financial loss, and potential identity theft.

PREVENTION TIPS

- Do not click on links in suspicious emails.
- Always verify payment issues by logging into Amazon through the official website.
- Check the sender’s email carefully for spoofing.
- Avoid entering financial details on unknown or redirected pages.
- Enable multi-factor authentication (MFA) on your account.

Email 3 — Google Docs Comment Phishing (Bitcoin Scam)


From: **Linda Martinez (Google Docs)** <comments-noreply@docs.google.com>
Date: Sun, Feb 19, 2023 at 5:55 AM
Subject: 💥 Action need, w... - I've got a new Bitcoin transaction to...
To: Redacted

Linda Martinez (lindamartinezvhpthkcqnqq@gmail.com) mentioned you in a comment in the following document

💥 Action need, withdrawing funds id - 6648602128

1 comment

💌 Action need, withdrawing funds id - 0257530

Linda Martinez • 5:50 AM, Feb 19 (PST) New

I've got a new Bitcoin transaction to share - take a look at it here: https://script.google.com/macros/s/AKfycbybzrn4l1OViqY1LYiWHz6b4m3zTmFHX4BYvDAD8DGI9qOeCpuaPrbpXe-

Figure 3: Suspicious Google Docs Comment Email

Subject: Action needed, I've got a new Bitcoin transaction

Sender: comments-noreply@docs.google.com (appears legitimate but spoofed/misused)

Email Type: Phishing

DESCRIPTION

This email appears to be a notification from Google Docs indicating that a user has been mentioned in a comment. The message includes a link and references a Bitcoin transaction, encouraging the user to click and review the details. It mimics a legitimate Google Docs notification but is used to lure users into clicking a malicious link.

ANALYSIS

This email represents a **social engineering attack** where attackers exploit trust in well-known platforms like Google Docs. By sending a fake comment notification, the attacker increases the likelihood that the user will click the link. The inclusion of a Bitcoin-related message is designed to attract attention and create urgency. Once clicked, the link may lead to a phishing page or malware download.

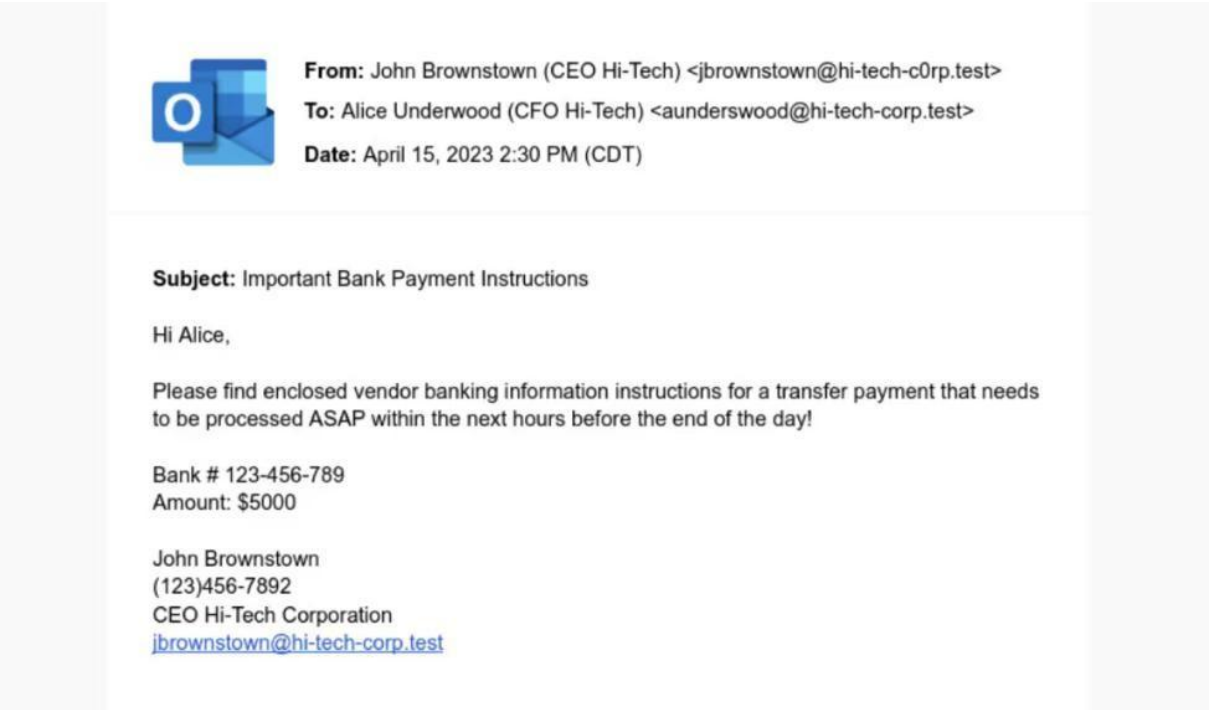
RISK / IMPACT

If the user clicks the malicious link, they may be redirected to a fake website designed to steal credentials or install malware. This can result in account compromise, financial loss, or unauthorized access to sensitive information.

PREVENTION TIPS

- Do not click on links from unexpected document comments.
- Verify the authenticity of the sender before taking action.
- Always check the URL before clicking (hover over links).
- Access Google Docs directly instead of using email links.
- Be cautious of messages involving cryptocurrency or urgent actions.

Email 4 — Business Email Compromise (CEO Fraud)



From: John Brownstown (CEO Hi-Tech) <jbrownstown@hi-tech-c0rp.test>
To: Alice Underwood (CFO Hi-Tech) <aunderswood@hi-tech-corp.test>
Date: April 15, 2023 2:30 PM (CDT)

Subject: Important Bank Payment Instructions

Hi Alice,

Please find enclosed vendor banking information instructions for a transfer payment that needs to be processed ASAP within the next hours before the end of the day!

Bank # 123-456-789
Amount: $5000

John Brownstown
(123)456-7892
CEO Hi-Tech Corporation
jbrownstown@hi-tech-corp.test

Figure 4: CEO Impersonation Email (Bank Transfer Request)
Subject: Important Bank Payment Instructions
Sender: jbrownstown@hi-tech-corp.test (appears internal but suspicious domain)
Email Type: Phishing (Business Email Compromise)

DESCRIPTION

This email appears to be sent from the CEO of a company to an employee requesting an urgent bank transfer. The message includes bank account details and emphasizes that the

payment must be completed immediately. It mimics a legitimate business communication but is designed to trick the recipient into transferring money.

ANALYSIS

This is a classic **Business Email Compromise (BEC)** attack, where attackers impersonate company executives to trick employees into transferring funds. These attacks rely heavily on social engineering, authority, and urgency rather than technical exploits. The attacker assumes the role of a trusted authority figure (CEO) to manipulate the recipient into acting quickly without verification.

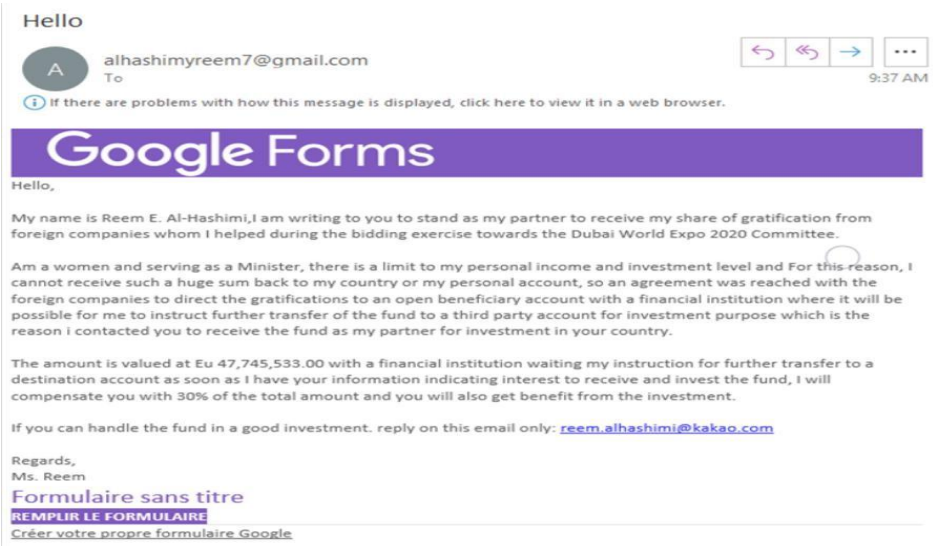
RISK / IMPACT

If the recipient processes the payment, it could result in **direct financial loss** to the organization. BEC attacks are one of the most damaging cyber threats, often leading to large monetary losses and reputational damage.

PREVENTION TIPS

- Always verify financial requests through **secondary communication channels** (call or in-person).
- Do not process urgent payments without proper authorization.
- Check sender email domains carefully.
- Implement approval workflows for financial transactions.
- Train employees to recognize CEO fraud and BEC attacks.

Email 5 — Google Forms Investment Scam (Advance Fee Fraud)


Hello

A alhashimyreem7@gmail.com
To
9:37 AM

If there are problems with how this message is displayed, click here to view it in a web browser.

Google Forms

Hello,

My name is Reem E. Al-Hashimi,I am writing to you to stand as my partner to receive my share of gratification from foreign companies whom I helped during the bidding exercise towards the Dubai World Expo 2020 Committee.

Am a women and serving as a Minister, there is a limit to my personal income and investment level and For this reason, I cannot receive such a huge sum back to my country or my personal account, so an agreement was reached with the foreign companies to direct the gratifications to an open beneficiary account with a financial institution where it will be possible for me to instruct further transfer of the fund to a third party account for investment purpose which is the reason i contacted you to receive the fund as my partner for investment in your country.

The amount is valued at Eu 47,745,533.00 with a financial institution waiting my instruction for further transfer to a destination account as soon as I have your information indicating interest to receive and invest the fund, I will compensate you with 30% of the total amount and you will also get benefit from the investment.

If you can handle the fund in a good investment. reply on this email only: reem.alhashimi@kakao.com

Regards,
Ms. Reem

Formulaire sans titre
REMPLIR LE FORMULAIRE
Créer votre propre formulaire Google

Figure 5: Google Forms Investment Phishing Email

Subject: (Not clearly specified – investment proposal message)
Sender: alhashimyreem7@gmail.com (personal email, not official)
Email Type: Phishing (Advance Fee Scam)

DESCRIPTION

This email claims to be from an individual offering a large financial investment opportunity related to international business and the Dubai World Expo. The sender requests assistance in transferring a large amount of money and promises a percentage of profit in return. It includes a Google Form link to collect user details.

ANALYSIS

This email is an example of an **advance fee fraud scam**, where attackers lure victims with promises of large financial gains. The use of Google Forms makes the attack appear legitimate while collecting sensitive user information. Such scams rely heavily on greed and trust rather than technical exploitation. Once the victim engages, the attacker may request upfront fees or personal details.

RISK / IMPACT

If the user responds or fills out the form, they may lose money or share sensitive personal and financial information. This can lead to financial fraud, identity theft, and long-term exploitation.

PREVENTION TIPS

- Avoid emails offering unrealistic financial opportunities.
- Do not trust unknown senders using personal email accounts.
- Never share financial or personal details via forms or emails.
- Verify investment opportunities through official channels.
- Be cautious of messages involving large sums of money.